Sittie Habiba Sarip-Paudac

Sittie Habiba Sarip-Paudac, more widely known as **Princess Habiba Sarip-Paudac** or simply **Princess Habiba**, is a Bangsamoro journalist, broadcaster, educator, and community advocate from Marawi City in the Bangsamoro Autonomous Region in Muslim Mindanao (BARMM).

She is of Maranao descent, one of the prominent Muslim ethnic groups of the Lanao region in Mindanao, and carries that heritage into every platform she steps onto.

On August 8, 2012, she made history as the **first Filipina news anchor to wear a hijab on national television**, breaking ground on PTV (People's Television Network) at a time when hijabi professionals in mainstream Philippine media were virtually non-existent.

Her on-air debut wasn't just a career milestone; it was a quiet but powerful act of representation for the broader Bangsamoro and Filipino Muslim community, a group that makes up roughly five to six percent of the Philippine population but had long remained underrepresented in national broadcasting.

Beyond the newsroom, she has served as Channel Manager and host of Salaam TV and co-host of Salaam Radio on Presidential Broadcast Services (PBS)/Radyo Pilipinas, platforms dedicated to showcasing Filipino Muslim stories, culture, and faith to audiences across the country.

In 2025, she received the **Bravo Woman for Media and Public Affairs** award from Security Bank and Zonta Club of Makati and Environs, one of only eight Filipinas honored that year.

Her signature legacy can be summed up in her own framing of the hijab: not a limitation, but the very thing that opened doors.

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Roots and Early Life

Sittie Habiba Sarip-Paudac was born into a Maranao family rooted in Marawi City, the capital of Lanao del Sur and the heart of Maranao cultural life in the Philippines.

Her family spent part of her childhood in Saudi Arabia, giving her early exposure to a broader Muslim world while keeping her deeply tied to her Maranao heritage and Filipino identity.

That cross-cultural upbringing likely shaped the worldview she'd later bring into broadcasting: a person equally at home discussing Islamic faith and navigating the dynamics of a largely Christian-majority Philippine media landscape.

Maranao culture is one of the richest in the Philippines, marked by intricate okir artistry, the epic oral tradition of the Darangen, and a deep communal emphasis on family, faith, and honor. These cultural roots are visible in how she carries herself publicly, with dignity, confidence, and a clear sense of purpose.

Education

She pursued higher education at **Mindanao State University (MSU)**, where she earned a **master's degree in English Language and Literature/Letters**.

She also pursued studies connected to the **University of the Philippines**, with a focus on public policy and advocacy.

That combination of literary training and policy awareness gave her a communication foundation that went well beyond reading scripts. It prepared her to engage with complex issues in nuanced, accessible ways, an ability that proved valuable in both the classroom and the studio.

Pre-Media Career

Before stepping in front of a camera, she built her professional foundation in education and community development.

She taught at the grade school level and later served as a college professor, experiences that sharpened her ability to explain complex ideas to diverse audiences.

She also worked with non-governmental organizations (NGOs) focused on community development, deepening her understanding of the real-world challenges facing communities across Mindanao.

Sittie Habiba Sarip-Paudac



Also known as	Princess Habiba Sarip-Paudac; Princess Habiba
Origin	Marawi City, Lanao del Sur, Philippines
Region	Bangsamoro Autonomous Region in Muslim Mindanao (BARMM)
Ethnicity	Maranao
Religion	Islam
Nationality	Filipino
Occupation(s)	Journalist, Broadcaster, Educator, Community Advocate
Known for	First Filipina news anchor to wear a hijab on national television (PTV, 2012)
Employer	People's Television Network (PTV); Presidential Broadcast Services / Radyo Pilipinas
Programs	Salaam TV; Salaam Radio

She had no formal broadcast training before entering the industry. What she brought instead was strong communication skills, cultural fluency, and a willingness to learn on the job, diving straight into the deep end.

Education	Master's in English Language and Literature/Letters, Mindanao State University; Public Policy and Advocacy studies, University of the Philippines
Awards	Bravo Woman for Media and Public Affairs (2025), Security Bank and Zonta Club of Makati and Environs

Career Breakthrough and Milestones

Joining PTV and Making History

In 2012, PTV (People's Television Network) was looking for its first hijab-wearing Muslim news anchor.

Princess Habiba auditioned in Manila, reportedly while en route to a Hong Kong trip, and landed the position.

On **August 8, 2012**, she made her on-air debut, becoming the **first Filipina news anchor to appear on national television wearing a hijab**.

Communities back home in Mindanao tuned in with pride. She wasn't simply reading the news; she was representing an entire segment of the Philippine population that had rarely seen itself reflected in the faces of mainstream media.

Her presence immediately challenged prevailing assumptions. Colleagues were surprised by her fluency in both English and Filipino (Tagalog), a reaction she turned into an opportunity to highlight the reality of educated, highly capable Bangsamoro women, including lawyers, doctors, professors, and now, a national television anchor.

She often found herself informally educating the newsroom about Islam, Maranao culture, and the realities of life in Mindanao, converting moments of unfamiliarity into conversations that built understanding.

Salaam TV and Salaam Radio

Under the Duterte administration, she took on expanded roles through the Presidential Communications Operations Office (PCOO).

She became **Channel Manager and host of Salaam TV**, a Muslim-oriented television program that showcases Filipino Muslim stories, culture, and faith for a national audience.

She also served as **co-host of Salaam Radio** on Presidential Broadcast Services (PBS)/Radyo Pilipinas, further extending her reach beyond television.

These platforms serve a dual purpose: educating non-Muslim Filipinos about Islam as a religion of peace and inclusivity, while also spotlighting the diverse Muslim ethnic groups across the Philippines and celebrating Bangsamoro identity and heritage.

She has continued delivering national newscasts and hosting programming that bridges cultural and religious divides within Philippine society.

Institutional Contributions

Through her roles at PTV, Salaam TV, and Salaam Radio, she has helped institutionalize Muslim representation in Philippine state broadcasting.

As Channel Manager of Salaam TV, she shaped editorial direction for a program with a national platform, ensuring that Bangsamoro voices and perspectives were presented with accuracy, dignity, and depth rather than reduced to stereotypes or crisis coverage.

Her work in both television and radio has contributed to a growing ecosystem of Bangsamoro media representation, demonstrating to other broadcasters and media institutions that Muslim Filipino professionals not only belong in national media but enrich it.

She has also participated in public events such as World Hijab Day, using those platforms to share her personal story and encourage Muslim women to pursue professional ambitions without compromising their faith.

Recognition and Awards

Her contributions to media and public affairs have been formally recognized at the national level.

In 2025, she received the **Bravo Woman for Media and Public Affairs** award, conferred by **Security Bank** in partnership with the **Zonta Club of Makati and Environs**. She was one of eight remarkable Filipinas honored through the program that year.

She dedicated the award to her family and the wider Bangsamoro community, framing the recognition not as a personal achievement alone but as a collective affirmation.

Her story has been featured in international and national media outlets, including Arab News and various Philippine publications, positioning her as a recognized symbol of empowered Bangsamoro womanhood on a global stage.

Cultural Significance

Princess Habiba's trailblazing role carries significant weight in the Philippine cultural and social context.

Filipino Muslims make up approximately five to six percent of the national population, concentrated primarily in Mindanao and the Sulu Archipelago, and have historically faced stereotyping, discrimination, and underrepresentation in mainstream media.

Her sustained visibility on national television since 2012 helped normalize the image of a hijabi professional in the public imagination, actively challenging narratives that had long reduced Bangsamoro identity to conflict and marginalization.

She embodies a form of cultural peacebuilding that works not through formal negotiations but through visibility: by humanizing Muslim Filipinos on air, correcting misconceptions in real time, and showcasing the vibrancy and richness of Bangsamoro culture, she has contributed to bridging one of the most historically complex divides in Philippine society.

Her story resonates particularly with young Muslim women navigating the tension between professional ambition and religious identity, demonstrating that the two are not in conflict but can, in fact, amplify each other.

Challenges

Despite her accomplishments, Princess Habiba's path was not without friction.

Entering a Manila-based newsroom as a hijabi Maranao woman meant confronting assumptions that she would need to set aside her religious expression to fit into the professional environment.

Colleagues' surprise at her fluency in English and Filipino underscored a deeper challenge: the persistent underestimation of educated Bangsamoro women in professional spaces outside of Mindanao.

She has also navigated the broader challenge of representing a diverse and complex community to a national audience that often lacks context. Being the lone visible Muslim face in a newsroom means carrying the informal burden of cultural ambassador on top of the professional duties of broadcasting.

She has consistently turned those challenges into platforms for dialogue rather than sources of bitterness, using them to create space for greater understanding and more accurate representation.

Personal Life, Values, and Family

She is married to a lawyer and is a proud mother of two sons. She has frequently credited her family as her greatest source of strength throughout her broadcasting career.

Her personal values are deeply rooted in Islamic faith. She speaks openly about her hijab not as a constraint but as a defining expression of her identity, the very thing that, in her words, took her to where she is today.

She is committed to da'wah in its most personal form: not through formal preaching but by living publicly as a faithful, professional Muslim woman and allowing that lived example to speak for itself.

She emphasizes modesty, professional excellence, and trust in divine providence, and she regularly advises young Muslim women to wear their hijabs with confidence, pursue their ambitions without apology, and trust that staying true to one's faith and identity is a strength, not a disadvantage.

Legacy

Sittie Habiba Sarip-Paudac didn't set out to be a pioneer. She showed up as herself, hijab, Maranao pride, professional drive, and all, and history met her there.

Her legacy is one of quiet but lasting impact: the visibility she created on a national stage in 2012 opened a conversation about Bangsamoro representation that continues to ripple through Philippine media, education, and public life.

She proved that authenticity is not a liability in professional spaces but a source of credibility and connection.

For the Bangsamoro community, she remains a living example that faith and ambition are powerful companions, and that the daughters of Mindanao belong wherever excellence is gathered.

See Also

- Bangsamoro Autonomous Region in Muslim Mindanao

- Maranao people
- Salaam TV
- People's Television Network (PTV)
- Bangsamoro
- Hijab
- Filipino Muslims

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Categories

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